

English Tenses

The tense system of English is probably one of the most daunting areas for many speakers of other languages. Multiple tenses should be taught through explaining strict grammar rules while allowing the students to practice proper structure, as well as evaluating themselves with quizzes and examples.

There are three different tenses in English: the past, the present and the future. Each of these tenses has four aspects: simple, continuous, perfect and perfect continuous.

The Present Simple

- Positive sentence: S + V (s / es) + O
- Negative sentence: S + do / does not + V_inf + O
- Question: Do / Does + S + V_inf + O?

Form with “To be”:

- Positive sentence: S + am/is/are + O
- Negative sentence: S + am/is/are not + O
- Question: Am/is/are + S + O?

The present simple tense is used to:

- Describe a truth
- Describe a habit, hobby, or action that repeatedly happens in the present
- Describe a schedule, a program, or a timetable

Signs for present simple tense:

In the sentence there are frequency words, such as: Everyday / night / week, often, usually, always, sometimes, etc.

Present continuous tense

- Positive sentence: S + am/is/are + V_ing + ...
- Negative sentence: S + am/is/are not + V_ing + ...
- Question: Am/Is/Are + S + V_ing + ...?

The present continuous tense is used to:

- Describe the action that is happening at the time of speaking
- Describe a planned action in the future
- Express a complaint about something, accompanied with “Always”
- Warn about something, suggest or order something

Signs for present continuous tense:

In the sentence there are adverbs of time, such as: Now, at the moment, at present, right now, etc. Or verbs at the beginning of the sentence to warn about something, suggest or order something, such as: look!, listen!, be quiet!, etc.

Present perfect tense

- Positive sentence: S + has/have + V3/ed + O
- Negative sentence: S + has/have not + V3/ed + O
- Question: Have/has + S + V3/ed + O?

The present perfect tense is used to:

- Describe an action that started in the past and still continues in the present and future
- Describe an action that was completed in the very recent past, expressed by 'just.'
- Describe an action that happened in the past but causes the consequence at present
- Describe experience

Signs for present simple tense:

In the sentence there are words, such as: Since, for, Already, just, ever, never, yet, recently, before, etc.

Past simple tense

- Positive sentence: S + V2/ed + O
- Negative sentence: S + did not + V_inf + O
- Question: Did + S + V_inf + O ?

Form with "To be":

- Positive sentence: S + was/were + O
- Negative sentence: S + were/was not + O
- Question: Was/were + S + O?

The past simple tense is used to:

- Describe an action that happened and ended at a time in the past
- Describe actions that happened consecutively in the past
- Describe a short action happened when another long action was taking place at a time in the past

Signs for past simple tense:

In the sentence there are words, such as, such as: Yesterday, last night/ last week/ last month/year, ago, etc.

Past continuous tense

- Positive sentence: S + were/ was + V_ing + O
- Negative sentence: S + were/was+ not + V_ing + O
- Question: Were/was+S+ V_ing + O?

The past continuous tense is used to:

- Describe an action that was happening at a time in the past
- Describe an action was happening in the past then interrupted by another short action
- Describe actions that were happening together at the same time in the past

Signs for past continuous tense:

There are adverbs of past time to mention a definite time in the sentence, such as: At/At this time + adverbs of past time (yesterday, last week, etc.); a specific time in the past (at 7 o'clock yesterday.)

Past perfect tense

- Positive sentence: S + had + V3/ed + O
- Negative sentence: S + had + not + V3/ed + O
- Question: Had + S + V3/ed + O?

The past perfect tense is used to:

- Describe an action that was completed before some point in the past
- Describe an action that was completed before another action in the past. The action that happened first uses the past perfect tense, the action that happened later uses the past simple tense

Signs for past perfect tense:

In the sentence there are words, such as: By the time, prior to that time, before, after, as soon as, until then, etc.

Adjectives and Adverbs

An adjective is a word or set of words that modifies (i.e., describes) a noun or pronoun. Adjectives may come before the word they modify.

Examples:

That is a cute puppy.

She likes a high school senior.

Adjectives may also follow the word they modify:

Examples:

That puppy looks cute.

The technology is state-of-the-art.

An adverb is a word or set of words that modifies verbs, adjectives, or other adverbs. Adverbs answer how, when, where, why, or to what extent—how often or how much (e.g., daily, completely).

Examples:

He speaks slowly (tells how)

He speaks very slowly (the adverb very tells how slowly)

They arrived today (tells when)

They will arrive in an hour (this adverb phrase tells when)

Let's go outside (tells where)

We looked in the basement (this adverb phrase tells where)

Bernie left to avoid trouble (this adverb phrase tells why)

Jorge works out strenuously (tells to what extent)

Jorge works out whenever possible (this adverb phrase tells to what extent)

Rule 1. Many adverbs end in *-ly*, but many do not. Generally, if a word can have *-ly* added to its adjective form, place it there to form an adverb.

Examples:

She thinks quick/quickly.

How does she think? *Quickly.*

*She is a **quick**/quickly thinker.*

Quick is an adjective describing *thinker*, so no *-ly* is attached.

*She thinks **fast**/fastly.*

Fast answers the question *how*, so it is an adverb. But *fast* never has *-ly* attached to it.

*We performed bad/**badly**.*

Badly describes *how* we performed, so *-ly* is added.

Rule 2. Adverbs that answer the question *how* sometimes cause grammatical problems. It can be a challenge to determine if *-ly* should be attached. Avoid the trap of *-ly* with **linking verbs** such as *taste*, *smell*, *look*, *feel*, which pertain to the senses. Adverbs are often misplaced in such sentences, which require adjectives instead.

Examples:

*Pat's roses smell **sweet**/sweetly.*

Do the roses actively smell with noses? No; in this case, *smell* is a linking verb—which requires an adjective to modify *roses*—so no *-ly*.

*The painter looked **angry**/angrily to us.*

Did the painter look with eyes, or are we describing the painter's appearance? We are describing appearance (the painter appeared angry), so no *-ly*.

*The painter looked angry/**angrily** at the paint splotches.*

Here the painter actively looked (using eyes), so the *-ly* is added.

Avoid this common mistake:

Incorrect: *Ingrid feels badly about the news.*

Ingrid is not feeling with fingers, so no *-ly*.

Correct: *Ingrid feels **bad** about the news.*

Rule 3. The word *good* is an adjective, whose adverb equivalent is *well*.

Examples:

You did a good job.

Good describes the job

You did the job well.

Well answers *how*.

You smell good today.

Good describes your fragrance, not how you smell with your nose, so using the adjective is correct.

You smell well for someone with a cold.

You are actively smelling with your nose here, so use the adverb.

Rule 4. The word *well* can be an adjective, too. When referring to health, we often use *well* rather than *good*.

Examples:

You do not look well today.

I don't feel well, either.

Rule 5. Adjectives come in three forms, also called **degrees**. An adjective in its normal or usual form is called a **positive degree adjective**. There are also the **comparative** and **superlative** degrees, which are used for comparison, as in the following examples:

Positive	Comparative	Superlative
<i>sweet</i>	<i>sweeter</i>	<i>sweetest</i>
<i>bad</i>	<i>worse</i>	<i>worst</i>
<i>efficient</i>	<i>more efficient</i>	<i>most efficient</i>

A common error in using adjectives and adverbs arises from using the wrong form of comparison. To compare two things, always use a **comparative** adjective:

Example: *She is the **cleverer** of the two women (never cleverest)*

The word *cleverest* is what is called the **superlative** form of *clever*. Use it only when comparing three or more things:

Example: *She is the **cleverest** of them all.*

Incorrect: *Chocolate or vanilla: which do you like best?*

Correct: *Chocolate or vanilla: which do you like **better**?*

Rule 6. There are also three degrees of adverbs. In formal usage, do not drop the *-ly* from an adverb when using the comparative form.

Incorrect: *Terry spoke quicker than Nguyen did.*

Correct: *Terry spoke **more quickly** than Nguyen did.*

Incorrect: *Talk quieter.*

Correct: *Talk **more quietly**.*

Incorrect: *Alfredo is the more efficient assembly worker in the unit.*

Correct: *Alfredo is the **most efficient** assembly worker in the unit.*

Rule 7. When *this*, *that*, *these*, and *those* are followed by a noun, they are adjectives. When they appear without a noun following them, they are pronouns.

Examples:

This house is for sale.

This is an adjective.

This is for sale.

This is a pronoun.

Passive/Active voice

An **active** sentence like **I drank two cups of coffee** has the subject first (the person or thing that does the verb), followed by the verb, and finally the object (the person or thing that the action happens to).

So, in this example, the subject is 'I', the verb is 'drank' and the object is 'two cups of coffee'.

But, we don't always need to make sentences this way. We might want to put the object first, or perhaps we don't want to say who did something. This can happen for lots of reasons (see the explanation further down the page). In this case, we can use a passive, which puts the object first:

- Two cups of coffee were drunk (we can add 'by me' if we want, but it isn't necessary).

How to make the Passive in English

We make the passive by putting the verb 'to be' into whatever tense we need and then adding the **past participle**. For regular verbs, we make the past participle by adding 'ed' to the infinitive. So **play** becomes **played**. [Click here to learn about irregular verbs](#).

Tense	Active	Passive
<u>present simple</u>	I make a cake.	A cake is made (by me).
<u>present continuous</u>	I am making a cake.	A cake is being made (by me).
<u>past simple</u>	I made a cake.	A cake was made (by me).
<u>past continuous</u>	I was making a cake.	A cake was being made (by me).
<u>present perfect</u>	I have made a cake.	A cake has been made (by me).
<u>pres. perf. continuous</u>	I have been making a cake.	A cake has been being made (by me).

past perfect

I **had made** a cake.

A cake **had been made** (by me).

future simple

I **will make** a cake.

A cake **will be made** (by me).

future perfect

I **will have made** a cake.

A cake **will have been made** (by me).

Reported Statements

When do we use reported speech? Sometimes someone says a sentence, for example "I'm going to the cinema tonight". Later, maybe we want to tell someone else what the first person said.

Here's how it works:

We use a 'reporting verb' like 'say' or 'tell'. ([Click here for more about using 'say' and 'tell'.](#)) If this verb is in the present tense, it's easy. We just put 'she says' and then the sentence:

- Direct speech: I like ice cream.
- Reported speech: She **says** (that) she **likes** ice cream.

We don't need to change the tense, though probably we do need to change the 'person' from 'I' to 'she', for example. We also may need to change words like 'my' and 'your'.

(As I'm sure you know, often, we can choose if we want to use 'that' or not in English. I've put it in brackets () to show that it's optional. It's exactly the same if you use 'that' or if you don't use 'that'.)

But, if the reporting verb is in the past tense, then usually we change the tenses in the reported speech:

- Direct speech: I like ice cream.
- Reported speech: She **said** (that) she **liked** ice cream.

Tense	Direct Speech	Reported Speech
present	I like ice cream	She said (that) she liked ice cream.

simple		
present continuous	I am living in London	She said (that) she was living in London.
past simple	I bought a car	She said (that) she had bought a car OR She said (that) she bought a car.
past continuous	I was walking along the street	She said (that) she had been walking along the street.
present perfect	I haven't seen Julie	She said (that) she hadn't seen Julie.
past perfect*	I had taken English lessons before	She said (that) she had taken English lessons before.
will	I'll see you later	She said (that) she would see me later.
would*	I would help, but..”	She said (that) she would help but...
can	I can speak perfect English	She said (that) she could speak perfect English.
could*	I could swim when I was four	She said (that) she could swim when she was four.
shall	I shall come later	She said (that) she would come later.
should*	I should call my mother	She said (that) she should call her mother
might*	I might be late	She said (that) she might be late
must	I must study at the weekend	She said (that) she must study at the weekend OR She said she had to study at the weekend

* doesn't change.

Occasionally, we don't need to change the present tense into the past if the information in direct speech is still true (but this is only for things which are general facts, and even then usually we like to change the tense):

- Direct speech: The sky is blue.
- Reported speech: She said (that) the sky **is/was** blue.

[Click here for a mixed tense exercise about practise reported statements.](#)

[Click here for a list of all the reported speech exercises.](#)

Reported Questions

So now you have no problem with making reported speech from positive and negative sentences. But how about questions?

- Direct speech: Where do you live?

How can we make the reported speech here?

In fact, it's not so different from reported statements. The tense changes are the same, and we keep the question word. The very important thing though is that, once we tell the question to someone else, it isn't a question any more. So we need to change the grammar to a normal positive sentence. A bit confusing? Maybe this example will help:

- Direct speech: Where do you live?
- Reported speech: She asked me where I lived.

Do you see how I made it? The direct question is in the present simple tense. We make a present simple question with 'do' or 'does' so I need to take that away. Then I need to change the verb to the past simple.

Another example:

- Direct speech: Where is Julie?
- Reported speech: She asked me where Julie was.

The direct question is the present simple of 'be'. We make the question form of the present simple of be by inverting (changing the position of) the subject and verb. So, we need to change them back before putting the verb into the past simple.

Here are some more examples:

Direct Question	Reported Question
Where is the Post Office, please?	She asked me where the Post Office was.
What are you doing?	She asked me what I was doing.
Who was that fantastic man?	She asked me who that fantastic man had been.

So much for 'wh' questions. But, what if you need to report a 'yes / no' question? We don't have any question words to help us. Instead, we use 'if':

- Direct speech: Do you like chocolate?
- Reported speech: She asked me **if** I liked chocolate.

No problem? Here are a few more examples:

Direct Question	Reported Question
Do you love me?	He asked me if I loved him.
Have you ever been to Mexico?	She asked me if I had ever been to Mexico.
Are you living here?	She asked me if I was living h

Reported Requests

There's more! What if someone asks you to do something (in a polite way)? For example:

- Direct speech: Close the window, please
- Or: Could you close the window please?
- Or: Would you mind closing the window please?

All of these requests mean the same thing, so we don't need to report every word when we tell another person about it. We simply use **'ask me + to + infinitive'**:

- Reported speech: She asked me to close the window.

Here are a few more examples:

Direct Request	Reported Request
Please help me.	She asked me to help her.
Please don't smoke.	She asked me not to smoke.
Could you bring my book tonight?	She asked me to bring her book that night.
Could you pass the milk, please?	She asked me to pass the milk.
Would you mind coming early tomorrow?	She asked me to come early the next day.

To report a negative request, use 'not':

- Direct speech: Please don't be late.
- Reported speech: She asked us **not** to be late.

Reported Orders

And finally, how about if someone doesn't ask so politely? We can call this an 'order' in English, when someone tells you very directly to do something. For example:

- Direct speech: Sit down!

In fact, we make this into reported speech in the same way as a request. We just use 'tell' instead of 'ask':

- Reported speech: She told me to sit down.

Direct Order Reported Order

Go to bed! He told the child to go to bed.

Don't worry! He told her not to worry.
Be on time! He told me to be on time.
Don't smoke! He told us not to smoke.

Time Expressions with Reported Speech

Sometimes when we change direct speech into reported speech we have to change time expressions too. We don't always have to do this, however. It depends on when we heard the direct speech and when we say the reported speech.

For example:

It's Monday. Julie says "I'm leaving **today**".

If I tell someone on Monday, I say "Julie said she was leaving **today**".

If I tell someone on Tuesday, I say "Julie said she was leaving **yesterday**".

If I tell someone on Wednesday, I say "Julie said she was leaving **on Monday**".

If I tell someone a month later, I say "Julie said she was leaving **that day**".

So, there's no easy conversion. You really have to think about when the direct speech was said.

Here's a table of some possible conversions:

now	then / at that time
today	yesterday / that day / Tuesday / the 27th of June
yesterday	the day before yesterday / the day before / Wednesday / the 5th of December
last night	the night before, Thursday night
last week	the week before / the previous week
tomorrow	today / the next day / the following day / Friday